

Are cultural cities always creative? An empirical analysis of culture-led development in 190 European cities

Valentina Montalto

Joint Research Centre, Ispra

valentina.montalto@ec.europa.eu

Valentina Alberti

Joint Research Centre, Ispra

valentina.alberti@ec.europa.eu

Francesco Panella

Joint Research Centre, Ispra

francesco.panella@ec.europa.eu

Pier Luigi Sacco*

University of Chieti-Pescara, ISPC-CNR Naples, and metaLAB (at) Harvard

pierluigi.sacco@unich.it, pierluigi_sacco@fas.harvard.edu

* Corresponding author: DiSFipeQ, University of Chieti-Pescara, Viale Pindaro, 42, 65127 Pescara, Italy.

Abstract. *There is a socio-economic threshold beyond which creative cities are at risk to become inaccessible to young, promising, but often low-income, cultural and creative professionals, thus undermining a major source of cultural dynamism. Building on this argument, scholars have increasingly weighed out the benefits of culture-led development. Yet, the literature dealing with this topic is mostly based on single case studies, failing to provide broad comparable evidence, particularly for European cities. To improve our understanding of how culture-led development may unfold in an urban context, we empirically analyse the creative and cultural performance of 190 cities in Europe, using the European Commission's Cultural and Creative Cities Monitor – a unique dataset that gathers 29 culture-related indicators for a very diverse sample of urban areas. We find that there is no strong correlation between empirical indicators of a city's cultural vibrancy and its creative economy performance. This may be due to deliberate policy choices, among which specialisation choices, or rather to unintended (and unsustainable) consequences of culture-led investment strategies that a deeper understanding of the interaction between the culture and creativity dimensions may help correct, if backed by sound empirical evidence.*

Keywords: Cultural cities; creative cities; Cultural and Creative Cities Monitor; Culture-led urban development.

1. Introduction

In the past forty years, an extremely rich and growing body of literature has explored the linkages between culture and urban development, largely focussing on the economic, social and image-related benefits that cities may derive from the combination of particular types of knowledge and 'soft factors', especially related to the rise of a new cognitive-cultural economy (Scott, 2008). The topic has been broadly covered also in institutional reports of international standing (e.g. UNCHS, 2004), that have demonstrated the emergence of culture-led approaches for cities attempting to preserve or improve their standing in an increasingly competitive global arena.

While scholars from different fields ranging from geography to cultural policies to urban studies have conceptualised the rationale behind these linkages (e.g. Scott, 2014) and the different routes these can take in policy practice (e.g. Vickery, 2007), another established literature stream from

this same varied set of disciplines has built upon the early culture-led regeneration practices of Glasgow 1990 and subsequent European capitals of culture in the later 1990s to highlight the tensions that may stem from urban policy's supposed 'panacea' of conflating creative/economic and cultural/artistic goals. Much of this literature is an open criticism to what has become the 'Creative City mantra' that the well-known creative class paradigm developed by Florida (2002, 2005) has contributed to popularise, particularly in policy circles. Despite its undeniable merits as regards the new visibility and relevance that the Creative City discourses have conferred to urban stakeholders, including cultural and creative workers and industries, scholars have highlighted numerous unintended consequences of creative cities policies. These range from the limited benefits in terms of capital gains of the arts sector to the lack of involvement of the local community (Landry & Bianchini, 1995) to the loss of production functions in favour of purely consumption-oriented retail districts to the choice of international style architecture, that lacks bonds with the local context and community, to phenomena of gentrification with consequent misplacement of long-established residents (Miles, 1997; 2000), often including low income, promising young artists. In other words, what remains controversial is the actual beneficiary of creative city policies (Markusen, 2006). As Florida has more recently recognised (2017), social cohesion and inclusion are equally critical conditions for sustainable development. Failing to acknowledge this may easily backfire, turning thriving cultural cities into increasingly exclusive and socio-economically unequal ones – a transition that however does not necessarily preclude success as defined by creative economy standards (Miles & Paddison, 2005; Navarro Yáñez, 2013; Peck, 2005).

The primary intention of this paper is to build upon the existing and by now established knowledge on the problematic consequences of some creative city policies to carry out a large-scale empirical study on the relation between the creative economy and cultural vitality as provided by the European Commission's Cultural and Creative Cities Monitor project on a unique and diversified sample of 190 cities located in 30 European countries (27 EU Member States, plus UK, Norway and Switzerland). As such, the paper mostly draws on the broad field of urban studies that intersects with culture-led and creative city policies.

There is clearly an endless body of studies that prove the flaws of such policies. However, most analyses of creative cities suffer from one of two main limitations. They either problematise the

creative city concept without providing evidence of its unintended (negative) consequences, or they do provide evidence but limited to a few specific case studies that make it difficult to generalise results.

Our goal here is not exploring new kinds of tensions in creative cities, so that this paper does not engage in analyses of specific policies, practices or impacts. We rather test the unique ability of the Cultural and Creative Cities Monitor's dataset to measure the actual level of association between creative/economic and cultural/artistic performances on a rich set of European cities. Our analysis highlights how such data may be helpful in revealing the often-implicit dilemmas between cultural and economic policy goals, making them statistically observable and measurable.

The remainder of the paper is structured as follows. First, we offer a concise overview of the conceptual roots that have shaped the culture-creativity link at urban level, with a main focus on its contentious character. Second, we introduce a tool, the Cultural and Creative Cities Monitor (Montalto et al., 2019), which enables us to empirically measure various dimensions of culture and creativity in 190 European cities. Third, we interpret and discuss results, focusing on the cultural/creative dimensions that prevail in different European cities, pointing to the main policy choices or contextual factors that may underpin these results. In the conclusions, we argue that sustainable 'city making' – a major policy objective today – requires a careful appreciation of the possibly contradictory directions that cultural investments may take, as confirmed by the empirical evidence provided in this paper.

2. Culture, creativity and urban change: policy rationale and embedded tensions

Artistic and cultural production is strongly intertwined with the life of cities. Cities have historically been the cradle of major art scenes and institutions, which in turn contributed to strengthen their prestige and attractiveness across the centuries. Yet, pulled by the spread of culture-led regeneration policies in urban settings (Miles & Paddison, 2005) and the success of the following creative city paradigm (Landry & Bianchini, 1995, Florida, 2002, 2004; Scott, 2010), culture has acquired a renewed legitimacy for policy makers and scholars as a main driver of urban creativity and vibrancy (Sacco, Ferilli and Tavano Blessi, 2014).

However, the origins of the creative city idea are not in culture (Scott, 2014). In Yencken's thoughts (1988) - one of the first authors writing about an aspirational 'creative city' - the creative city is shaped by many factors, including the combined capacity to be economically efficient and emotionally appealing. In addition to that, for Yencken, a creative city should also provide cultural opportunities that matter to people, providing them with occasions for active creative expression and not just for passive aesthetic experience. He stresses the role of artists and their creative capacity to re-signify and repurpose daily human affairs in an emotionally engrossing way, contributing to shaping a city's unique ambience and charm.

This first argument is in line with Landry's comprehensive formulation of the idea a few years later. Creativity is at the core of the creative city paradigm, and is expected to re-energize all aspects of urban existence, including the cultural life of the city (Landry, 2000). In his collaborative work with Bianchini (Landry & Bianchini, 1995), he sees creativity as a method to cultivate a city's cultural resources to help cities in their 'soul searching' process of finding a new identity and purpose in a context of post-industrial restructuring. Artists and their creativity are valued for their capacity to connect to the local communities, to anticipate socio-cultural change and to provide fresh ideas and insights in tackling social challenges.

Alongside this first line of thought, some geographers and sociologists started to focus attention upon the cultural economy of cities (Lash & Urry, 1994; Molotch, 1996; Pratt, 1997; Scott, 1996), and these ideas rapidly intertwined with work on the creative city. Culture and creativity are conceptualised here as production inputs to highly specific economic production systems which produce goods and services with high intensity of aesthetic and symbolic content. A self-reinforcing process is established between the city and its cultural and creative assets: the city provides a stimulating environment to its creative workers, who in turn help grow and enrich the city's cultural and economic capital.

Overall, research on the urban and regional foundations of creativity was still relatively peripheral until the late 1990s. The early 2000s marked a turning point, with the publication of Richard Florida's influential (2002) book on the rise of the 'creative class' – an event that almost immediately sparked off a burgeoning debate about creativity as a dynamic force of urban development. The argument is notoriously that *'places with a flourishing artistic and cultural environment are the ones that generate economic outcomes and overall economic growth'*

(Florida, 2002, p. 261), not just because of the direct economic impact of the cultural and creative industries but mostly because of the socio-economically transformational power of high-human-capital workers and professionals (the creative class) upon places with clear but as yet untapped cultural potential that result particularly attractive to them (Cunningham, 2012).

The ensuing, growing tide of research and the popularisation of the creative city idea brought about by the ‘creative class’ approach may be seen in perspective as the mature fruit of the strong, sudden ‘cultural turn’ of urban policies taking place in the 1990s (see among others, Montgomery, 1990; Bianchini & Parkinson, 1993; Hall, 2000; Kong, 2000). The renewal programmes that have been promoted ever since in a number of North American (see among others Grodach, 2012 and Ponzini and Rossi, 2010 on the cases of Austin and Baltimore) and West European cities, many of which in the latter case under the auspices of the European Capital of Culture initiative (see e.g. Tasmin & O’ Brien, 2012 on Liverpool), can be considered as the stepping stone of the culturalisation of urban policies (Ponzini & Rossi, 2010). In practice, however, such cultural turn has been far from monolithic, translating into a number of different approaches and views, ranging from staging arts and cultural projects in the urban space with very different degrees of integration into urban development strategies (Evans & Shaw, 2004; Vickery, 2007), to culture being promoted in the form of localised complexes of cultural-products industries (Scott, 2000), to clusters facilitating the process of strategic adaptation and change across the whole economy (Potts, 2009; Sacco and Crociata, 2013), and to culturally vibrant scenes being regarded as an attractive consumption asset for highly educated classes of workers (Florida, 2002, 2004).

The uptake of the creative city ‘discourse’ generated undeniable benefits, ranging from the emergence of new conceptual frameworks ‘bringing the dimensions of economy, culture, and place back into some sort of practical and humanly reasonable harmony’ (Scott, 2006, p. 15), to a renewed policy focus on the arts and cultural sectors from the perspective of both production and consumption, which empowered these sectors’ arguments for increased funding and support from government agencies (Moore & Cherry, 2015), to the emergence of new arts and culture consultancies that further contributed to introduce artists into public commissions (Vickery, 2007).

Policy implementation has however remained fraught with partial and sometimes contradictory achievements, dampening the initial optimism about culture-led regeneration strategies. The first

wave of critical response mostly pointed to the varied degrees of integration of cultural components in urban regeneration plans, to the limited benefits for the arts sector in terms of capital gains compared to the real estate sectors as well as to unmet local needs and interests, due to the lack of involvement of local communities – an issue that arose from the very early stages (Bianchini & Landry, 1994) and that has remained relevant throughout. Critics from the interdisciplinary field of ‘urban studies’ immediately followed, with a major emphasis on how public space and the new aesthetics of the city were being (negatively) affected by political prioritisation of a ‘leisure-retail led’ regeneration disguised by a policy rhetoric of culture-led regeneration (Miles, 1997; 2000; McCarthy, 2002). The advent and decline of the ‘creative class’ paradigm carried with it an additional load of critical arguments (see for instance Moore-Cherry, 2015, for a good overview of main critiques) that partially echoed earlier rounds of criticisms – see among others Chatterton (2000) on the lack of citizens’ empowerment in the public debate on urban developmental strategies, or Cunningham (2012) on the cultural consumption/leisure approach mainstreamed by the ‘creative class’ approach as opposed to the production-centric creative economy conceptualisations by authors such as Saxenian (1996), Sassen (1994), Scott (2000), Storper (Storper & Scott, 2009), Markusen (2006), and Curtin (2003). The implications of the creative class paradigm in terms of social justice are particularly noticeable. While some scholars have studied effects on class, gender and racial inequality (Leslie & Catungal, 2012; McCann, 2007; Peck, 2005), others have more specifically emphasised the contradiction between the role of artists and creatives in shaping cities and the prioritisation of the interests of public administrations and private investors. Artists and creatives (together with disenfranchised former residents) become the inevitable victims of the ensuing processes of redevelopment and gentrification. The policy implementation of ‘creative class’ approaches physically expels them from urban neighbourhoods, undermines their civic agency, and disrupts the local cultural milieu (McClean, 2014; Novy & Colomb, 2013). Such tensions derive from diverging priorities and goals across stakeholders. The struggle to reconcile the interests and perspectives of cultural producers, and the recognition of their contribution to urban quality of life, with urban policy agendas failing to give due representation to such concerns is deep-seeded, and has serious consequences in terms of urban inclusion and long-term social sustainability.

From this necessarily brief literature review, it appears that the relationship between culture, creativity and cities may be built along different dimensions, which are often complementary but

also possibly conflicting. There is in principle no theoretically compelling reason to expect that the local factors that allow a city to qualify as ‘cultural’ according to certain criteria also cause it to qualify as ‘creative’ according to different criteria, and attempts at giving a ‘creative’ turn to strongly characterized ‘cultural’ cities may prove challenging (Zeng et al., 2020). While the dominance of non-cultural or even anti-cultural motivations within broader urban regeneration objectives (Vickery, 2007) may be a self-evident reason for missing out cultural vitality objectives, various scholars have in addition demonstrated the essential role that the specific contextual factors including prior economic development and local institutions and actors (Leslie & Rantisi, 2006; Barnes & Hutton, 2009; Grodach, 2012) play in determining the actual scope and impacts of culture-led urban policies.

Has this (often) confrontational relation been solved since the first uptakes of culture-led policies, about forty years ago? And to what extent do urban empirical metrics (still) reflect the heterogeneous policy approaches to culture-led development highlighted in our review and the observed tensions between the creative/economic and artistic/cultural objectives? Such questions are particularly timely in the light of the need to keep promoting creative cities that are first and foremost inclusive and sustainable (e.g., Darlow, 1996; Kagan and Hahn, 2012; Alsayela, de Jong & Fransena, 2022).

3. The Cultural and Creative Cities Monitor: data and methods

Despite the popularity of the culture- and creativity-led development approach in urban studies and policy, there is a scarcity of comprehensive and comparable metrics of culture and creativity at city level. The Cultural and Creative Cities Monitor (hereinafter: the Monitor) developed by the Joint Research Centre of the European Commission is precisely intended to fill this knowledge gap.

While the full rationale and methodology underpinning the Monitor can be found elsewhere (Montalto et al., 2017; Montalto et al., 2019), here we briefly recall the three main steps that informed its development: (i) a double-fold literature review drawing on the culture-led regeneration and the composite indicators research stream, with focus on those indices that –

partially or totally – cover culture; (ii) identification and gathering of relevant and available data on culture at city level, based on five quality criteria¹; (iii) conceptual and statistical analysis, on the basis of which 29 indicators have finally been retained out of an initial dataset of around 200.

In a nutshell, as the complexity of culture cannot actually be captured by a narrow definition, attention has been placed on (some) meaningful aspects that can empirically be measured by making the most of available data, which come from both Europe-wide official statistics and ‘experimental’ web-based sources. As such, the Monitor conceptualises and measures nine main dimensions of cities’ cultural and creative milieux, which relate to three aspects (see Table 1). First, ‘Cultural Vibrancy’ measures the presence of diverse participation opportunities, which is notably captured by ‘physical quantities’ of culture-related venues (Throsby, 2001, p. 46) as well as the capacity of such venues to attract audiences, as reflected in indicators such as ‘number of museum visitors’. Second, ‘Creative Economy’ addresses the contribution of culture to a city’s

¹ The Monitor combines data from various sources and complements them with data from web sources. For most indicators, the Monitor uses a city-specific dataset (Eurostat’s Urban Audit). For other elements, e.g. number of graduates in arts, humanities and ICT or the percentage of people satisfied with cultural facilities in their city, it uses data from thematic datasets covering topics such as education and quality of life, the European Tertiary Education Registry, and the European Commission’s survey on the Quality of Life in Cities. In order to get the most robust measure possible with the smallest number of indicators, the Monitor considers and combines five selection criteria: *coverage* (data available for at least 50% of the city sample); *availability* (either as peer-reviewed scientific data, as data provided by international organisations or as ‘experimental data’ coming from the web); verifiable *quality* (official statistics, quality control performed or best available data at the moment of data collection); *timeliness* (representing most up-to-date datasets available at the moment of the data collection); and *relevance* (based on the literature as well as on the opinion of a group of fifteen experts with proven knowledge and expertise in culture and urban development matters who joined two consultation workshops). In addition, robustness checks show that the C3 Index and its three sub-indices are robust to changes in the dimension weights and the normalisation method, for the majority of the cities analysed.

economy, through indicators relating to creative and knowledge-based jobs and innovation outputs (e.g. ICT patents and new designs). Third, the ‘Enabling Environment’ focuses upon some hard and soft conditions that favour the development of lively cultural environments and flourishing creative economies, such as the availability of different typologies of transport connections, the level of diversity, tolerance and trust, and the efficiency of the governance system (e.g. Landry & Bianchini, 1995; Van Der Borg, Russo, Lavanga, & Mingardo, 2005).

Indicators covering each of these three aspects are aggregated in order to obtain three synthetic measures of performance (i.e. the ‘Cultural Vibrancy’, the ‘Creative Economy’ and the ‘Enabling Environment’ sub-indices) that assess cities on a 0-100 scale, where higher scores signal better performance.

Table 1 The Cultural and Creative Cities’ Monitor: conceptual framework and indicators.

Sub-Indices	Dimensions	Indicators
Cultural Vibrancy	Cultural Venues & Facilities	Sights & landmarks
		Museums & art galleries
		Cinemas
		Concert & music halls
	Cultural Participation & Attractiveness	Theatres
		Tourist overnight stays
		Museum visitors
		Cinema attendance
Creative Economy	Creative Knowledge-based Jobs	Satisfaction with cultural facilities
		Jobs in arts, culture & entertainment
		Jobs in media & communication
		Jobs in other creative sectors
	Intellectual Property & Innovation	ICT patent applications
		Community design applications
	New Jobs in Creative Sectors	Jobs in new arts, culture & entertainment enterprises
		Jobs in new media & communication enterprises
Enabling Environment	Human Capital & Education	Jobs in new enterprises in other creative sectors
		Graduates in arts & humanities
		Graduates in ICT

		Average appearances in university rankings
	Openness, Tolerance & Trust	Foreign graduates
		Foreign-born population
		Tolerance of foreigners
		Integration of foreigners
		People trust
	Local & International Connections	Passenger flights
		Potential road accessibility
		Direct trains to other cities
	Quality of Governance	Quality of governance

In the absence of an operational definition of ‘creative cities’, the 190 included in this monitoring project ultimately include those, in 30 European countries (EU-27, plus UK, Norway and Switzerland), that share a common developmental focus on culture and creativity, meaning a willingness to invest, at different levels and with different modalities, in local cultural resources and foster creative endeavours with a view to sustain socioeconomic growth. To ‘proxy’ such engagement, three criteria were finally retained. The final sample thus includes 190 cities spanning the full size range from global metropolises to small, dynamic towns, namely 98 cities that have won or have been shortlisted for the title of European Capital of Culture; 33 UNESCO Creative Cities; and 59 cities that host at least two major permanent cultural festivals.

The selection of pertinent metrics to capture culture and creativity is clearly far from being a trivial exercise. The indicators included in the Monitor ‘merely’ represent 29 *measurable* aspects of the selected cities that are consistent with the multi-dimensional foundations of culture discussed in the literature. More particularly, the Monitor succeeds in breaking from a narrowly economic perspective of culture (i.e. ‘Creative Economy’ sub-index), by additionally considering, among others, the driving role of cultural venues and cultural participation (i.e. the ‘Cultural Vibrancy’ sub-index).

But to what extent are highly performing urban creative economies also culturally vibrant cities?

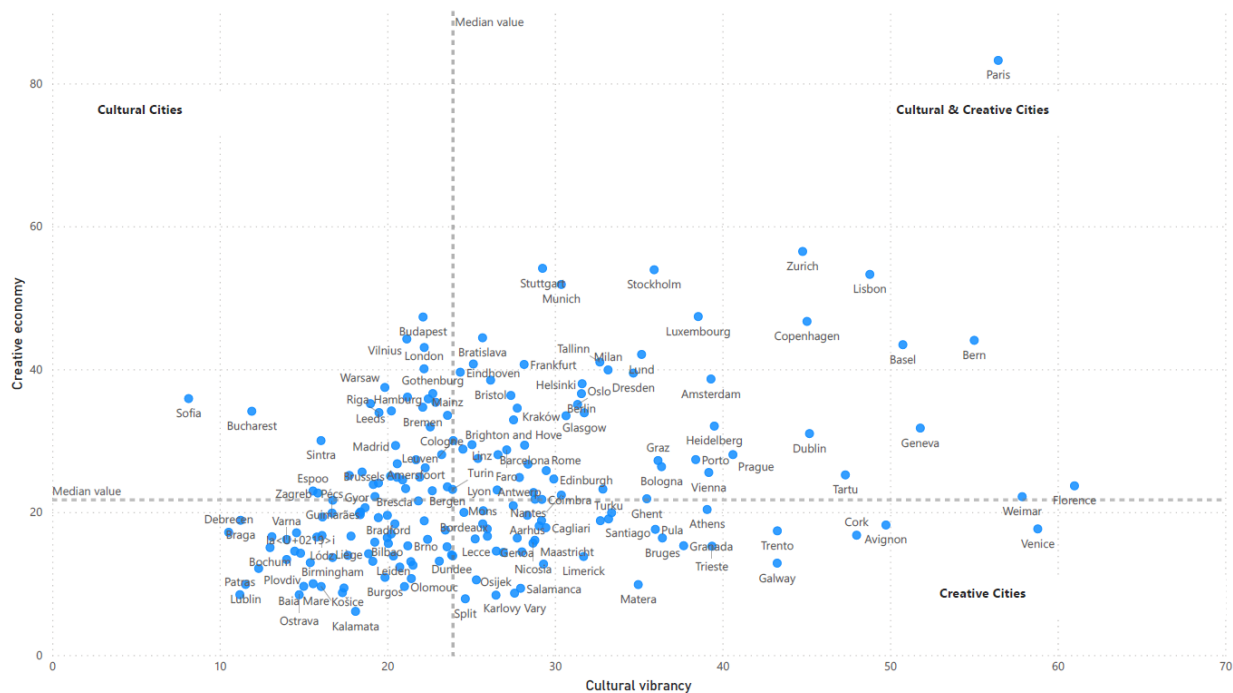
Building on the analytical power offered by this unique type of tool, we focus our analysis on the relation between these two aspects, as empirically measured by the Monitor’s relevant sub-indices. From a methodological perspective, we proceed in two steps. First, we assess how cities perform

on the ‘Cultural Vibrancy’ and ‘Creative Economy’ sub-indices and, more precisely, whether their score is above / below the median value for all the 190 European cities included in the sample (Figure 1). We label the resulting quadrants as follows: ‘Cultural and Creative Cities’, ‘Cultural Cities’ and ‘Creative Cities’ for cities recording a score higher than the median on both sub-indices (upper right quadrant) or only on the ‘Cultural Vibrancy’ (upper left quadrant) or ‘Creative Economy’ (lower right quadrant), respectively. The remaining lower left quadrant identifies the ‘below-median’ cities, meaning those cities that, despite their active engagement in promoting the emergence of a cultural and creative milieu, still under-perform on both dimensions. We then take one step further by considering the role of two contextual variables in determining the ‘Cultural Vibrancy’ and ‘Creative Economy’ performance. To this purpose, we produce two different box plots. A box plot is a method for charting the distribution of numerical data, taking the minimum, first quartile, median, third quartile, and maximum value of the distribution as reference points. In this case, the two box plots show how the two scores vary in cities grouped in five income and population groups, respectively (for more details on how the groups are obtained, see Montalto et al. 2019).

4. How cultural and creative are European cities?

As it is easily seen from Figure 1, there is no simple, positive correlation between the size of the creative economy and the cultural vibrancy of a city.

Figure 1. Cities' performance on Cultural Vibrancy and Creative Economy.



There are of course many cities that excel on both sub-indices, but there are also many others that perform above the sample median on one scale, but under median on the other. And even within the cities that do well on both dimensions, there is not a clear hierarchy: also in this case, we find cities that do relatively better on one side than on the other, confirming the principle that each city features its own specific mix. For instance, Stuttgart, Stockholm, and Munich, while excelling on both dimensions, are much more creative than cultural, whereas in the same category Florence and Weimar are way more cultural than creative. Sofia and Bucharest are excellent on the creative side, but under-performing on the cultural. Vice versa, Bruges and Venice are excellent on the cultural side, but under-performing on the creative one.

In other words, at the top of the Cultural and Creative Cities Monitor rankings in the various dimensions we find not only the usual suspects such as London, Paris, Milan, or Amsterdam, but also cities like Karlsruhe, Lund, Tartu, or Galway - which are not the first that come to mind when we think of the typical European cultural city - as well as well-known heritage cities such as Florence, Weimar, or Avignon. There are, therefore, many different successful models, and this, essentially, means one thing: that every city can reasonably aspire to become a thriving cultural city, if only it is able to fully express its own potential and to build its own, place-specific mix.

What this data tells us is that there is no simple recipe to help a city thrive by means of culture. Strategic goals may differ: one may be more interested in direct economic impact (so that the size of the creative economy is the primary concern, either in terms of employment or innovation outputs), or in making culture a cradle of future creative talent (so that we should instead look at cultural vibrancy and its instrumental value at attracting creatives).

As shown by Figures 2 and 3, contextual conditions do also matter to a certain extent. The analysis of scores by income per capita and population groups offers various interesting insights in this respect.

On the one hand, the levels of Cultural Vibrancy and Creative Economy are significantly different in European cities with different income per capita, suggesting that both cultural and creative vitality may benefit from higher income opportunities. This may be the result of the concurrence of several factors. In relatively richer cities, public and private resources for investments in cultural infrastructure and for the financing of ambitious cultural initiatives and events are generally more abundant. Likewise, in richer cities there is better availability of investment in new and emerging creative businesses and there is a higher spending capacity in creative products. Moreover, in relatively richer cities artists, cultural and creative professionals all generally face more and better paid job opportunities, and this in turn positively influences their career prospects and accomplishments. Such joint, favourable conditions positively impact upon the city's cultural vitality. In turn, a more culturally vital, high-income city is likely to reinforce its economic competitiveness, attracting more valuable human resources and skills, increasing its touristic appeal, and so on, further improving economic conditions. Interestingly, income has a positive effect both in terms of Cultural Vibrancy and Creative Economy, but the effect is more pronounced in the latter case. A rich and thriving creative city generally offers much more prestigious and better paid professional opportunities in strongly market-oriented creative sectors such as media, advertising, and fashion than a relatively poorer one. Consequently, the score gap between relatively richer vs. poorer cities is large, and especially so between the extremes of the spectrum. In a culturally vibrant city, better availability of economic resources is also beneficial, but a less market-oriented cultural talent may thrive in relatively poorer urban environments as well, so that the score gap between relatively richer vs. poorer cities at the extremes of the spectrum is less dramatic and there is more generally less inequality of scores across the various income groups.

On the other hand, Cultural Vibrancy and Creative Economy are influenced in fundamentally different ways by city size. Cultural Vibrancy does not significantly differ in European cities with different population size, so that, on average, small cities may be as good as big cities in that respect, and in fact small cities may even be (slightly) more vibrant than large and very large ones. For the cultivation and expression of cultural talent, small may be beautiful, possibly also because of more favourable and more relaxed living conditions with respect to metropolises. On the other hand, in terms of Creative Economy city size makes a clear difference, and very large cities enjoy a major advantage with respect to all other city size groups, and especially with respect to medium and small cities. The reason is that in large cities the more market-oriented creative sectors find better opportunities both on the supply and the demand sides which are essentially related to city size. The divergence of the effect of city size on Cultural Vibrancy vs. Creative Economy scores is an interesting result that deserves to be further investigated in future research.

To sum up, as regards Cultural Vibrancy, the performance of European cities differs across income groups but not across size groups, suggesting that cities of different size may provide alternative, successful models of cultural vibrancy, whereas availability of resources makes a difference, as it could be expected. As regards Creative Economy, the performance of European cities does significantly differ across income groups as well as population groups².

Overall, income levels are better predictors of the scores of European cities under observation than population size, but in the case of the Creative Economy the two variables are mutually reinforcing – a result that resonates well with the literature on the tendency of cultural and creative industries to concentrate in densely populated areas in terms of people and economic activities (see next subsection).

² The results of the Wilcoxon test (a non-parametric statistical hypothesis test used for non-normally distributed data, like the ones under analysis) are as follows: ‘Cultural Vibrancy’: all income groups are significantly different from each other, except groups 2 and 3, but there are not significant differences between population groups; ‘Creative Economy’: all income groups are significantly different from each other, while most population groups are statistically different from each other, in particular the Extra-Extra Large group is significantly different from the Large, Medium and Small groups but not from the Extra-Large group. Also, the Small and Medium groups are not significantly different. Results are available upon request.

Figure 2. Box plots of 'Cultural Vibrancy' and 'Creative Economy' scores by income groups

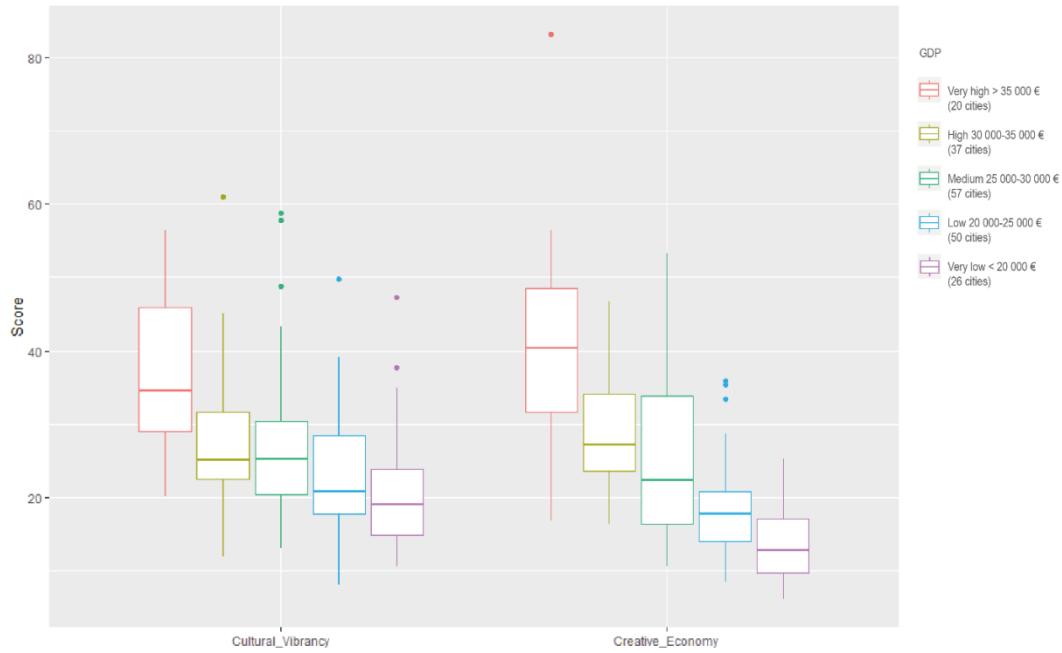
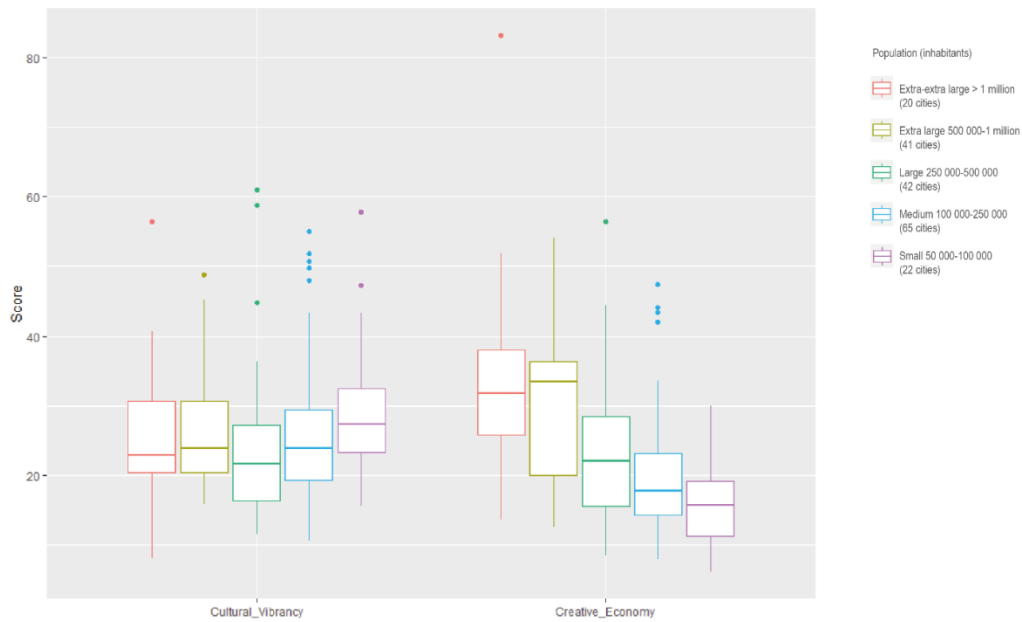


Figure 3. Box plots of 'Cultural Vibrancy' and 'Creative Economy' scores by population groups



Note: each interval is built around five values: minimum score, the first quartile, the median, the third quartile, and the maximum score. Points outside the intervals represent outliers.

5. Discussion

Most analyses of creative cities problematise the creative city concept providing little or no evidence of its unintended (negative) consequences, on the basis of a few specific case studies. Using data from the Cultural and Creative Cities Monitor, we were able to examine, empirically, the relation between the creative economy and cultural vitality of 190 European cities.

The unique ability of this dataset to allow us to test for the actual level of association between creative and cultural performances on such a diversified sample of cities, enables us to offer three main considerations on the reasons behind our results.

First, as extensively discussed in our literature review, the ‘Cultural Vibrancy’ and ‘Creative Economy’ constructs are proxies of inherently different phenomena, which can be part of a positive feedback loop under specific conditions that relate to local structural and environmental factors and policy choices. Moreover, the analysis of the results by city size carried out elsewhere (Mareque, Creo, & Álvarez-Díaz, 2021; Montalto et al., 2019) confirms the importance of contextual conditions. On average, small and medium cities in the sample perform at least as well as big cities on ‘Cultural Vibrancy’, confirming the thesis that also smaller cities may thrive upon their own kind of outstanding cultural resources (Lorentzen & Van Heur, 2011; Richards & Duif, 2018). Instead, big cities, among which many national capitals, score best on ‘Creative Economy’, very likely due to the tendency of cultural and creative industries to concentrate in densely populated areas (Boix, Hervás-Oliver, & De Miguel-Molina, 2015; Cooke & Lazzeretti, 2007; Lazzeretti, Boix, & Capone, 2008) to benefit from agglomeration economies (Lorenzen & Frederiksen, 2008; Turok, 2003). In conclusion, cities that are both culturally and economically vibrant to a substantial extent seem to be rather an exception than the rule. In most cases we find a trade-off between the two dimensions, whose balance is clearly influenced by specific constellations of local factors, among which policy choices.

In fact – and here we introduce our second remark – the specific performance of most cities could be the effect of deliberate policy choices, albeit mediated by specific political and institutional factors (Grodach, 2016). Said differently, local governments might consciously opt for a highly specialised cultural/creative economy profile, with the support of local institutions and actors. In this sense, the French city of Avignon’s plan to position itself as a festival city (since 1947, the

city hosts the ‘Festival d’Avignon’, one of the major contemporary theatre festivals in the world), might help explain its position in the ‘Cultural Cities’ quadrant (Figure 2). The city scores 50/100 on ‘Cultural Vibrancy’ and 85/100 on the underlying ‘Theatres’ indicator, very well above similar cities in terms of income, employment and population size. Similarly, Kaunas’ efforts to be internationally recognised as a ‘design city’ help explain the positioning of Lithuania’s second city in the ‘Creative Cities’ quadrant (Figure 2). The city scores 24/100 on ‘Creative Economy’ and 53/100 on the underlying indicator ‘Jobs in arts, culture & entertainment’, again considerably above its peers, a result that is clearly reflected in national CCS mappings (Daubaraite & Startiene, 2012). Kaunas’ arts and design community is an increasingly credited cultural actor, determined to revitalise and promote the city and its modernist architecture, also thanks to its current title of European Capital of Culture 2022, and to the title of UNESCO Creative City of Design, obtained in 2015.

Finally and importantly, a thriving creative economy might come at the expense of a more gentrified, unequal and ultimately culturally poorer city (Sacco, Williams, & Del Bianco, 2007), due to departure of talented young artists and arts professionals and to a less diversified and attractive cultural offer, a situation that is likely conducive to a lower score on cultural vibrancy as compared to creative economy indicators.

6. Conclusions

In the last two decades, the creative city has become a popular branding and a widely adopted policy script by cities all over the world. The ‘creative’ tag is associated with a range of socially desirable, euphoric factors, evoking opportunities for (cultural) self-expression, imagination, and community cohesion. However, there is now a broad critical literature suggesting that, across the documented examples of creative city strategies, culture is not always generating win-win outcomes for all local stakeholders (Pratt, 2011). Instead, the emphasis on local economic growth through the boosting of the creative economy, the global, often fierce competition among entrepreneurial cities, and the outcomes of many top-down culture-driven urban regeneration interventions have sometimes worsened the liveability of certain cities. The COVID-19 pandemic

has clearly exposed and even exacerbated existing inequalities in cultural and creative cities, flagging a need for new, better targeted approaches to culture-led development.

This paper was inspired by the opportunity to derive new insights by combining existing knowledge on the problematic consequences of some creative city policies with the empirical evidence on the creative economy and cultural vitality of 190 European cities provided by the European Commission's Cultural and Creative Cities Monitor project. We found that the 'Cultural Vibrancy' and 'Creative Economy' constructs (respectively proxied by indicators of cultural infrastructure and cultural audiences, and creative jobs and innovation outputs e.g., patents and new designs) are weakly correlated, suggesting that the ambition of cities to excel in both creative *and* cultural terms somewhat remains 'wishful thinking', and possibly even a misconception. We find that a limited number of cities perform very well on both dimensions. However, most of the cities under analysis are characterised by different, and sometimes *very* different results in terms of 'Cultural Vibrancy' vs. 'Creative Economy'.

A review of the creative city literature offers good interpretive keys for this finding. First, culture and creativity can mutually enrich each other in various ways. We have shown how the mechanisms highlighted by the creative city literature are very different and generate different results. Investment in a culturally vibrant scene can lead to increased creative self-expression and community empowerment, to a more cosmopolitan creative class and a cooler city, to a thriving cultural and creative industry, or to an innovative local economy. A successful creative economy is thus only one of the possible outcomes of a much broader and manifold set of policy goals. While creative city strategies often aim at achieving *all* these goals, actual implementation choices cause policy makers to focus on different alternatives that *de facto* prioritise one goal over the others, e.g., in terms of economically or socially oriented investment and policy choices. Second, and a consequence of the former point, a poor understanding of the real trade-offs behind creative city policy menus may lead to unintended results, as the prioritisation of one goal unexpectedly leads to disappointing results as to the others. Third, it is not only a matter of policies: culture-led development strategies are not place-neutral. On average, big cities are more likely to perform better in terms of creative economy. Contextual effects can be mitigated by specific historical paths, local skill pools or well-targeted policies, as the few exceptions of smaller cities that are well-performing on the creative economy dimension, such as Linz in Austria, seem to confirm.

However, the lack of a strong correlation between cultural vibrancy and creative economy does not imply that they are necessarily conflicting. This result may rather suggest that the development of a local creative economy need *not* to be a prioritised policy goal for all cities, and that other forms of creativity (that are more difficult to be captured in a comparative perspective) have rather been pursued (e.g., creativity for local social cohesion and inclusive creative expression). This is not to understate the importance of the economic dimension of creativity. However, in a historical moment in which there is an increasing call for more human-centred, socially sustainable cities (a call that goes back to key authors such as Jane Jacobs, 1961, and Henri Lefebvre, 1968), local policymakers seem to be more open to consider alternative development models that frame economic performance as one among many other dimensions of development, rather than the primary one. This implies in turn the need to properly understand and strategically tackle the often-subtle trade-offs between all these relevant dimensions. Failure to do this properly may result in a misleading scapegoating of culture as a failed developmental driver while in fact the real issue should be traced back to poor policy design and implementation, caused in turn by a fatal misconception of the development model and of the related policy menu, constraints, and viable outcomes. If, on the contrary, culture is acknowledged in its many forms and potential developmental effects not as a ‘magic wand’, but as a complex, multi-dimensional playground with its specific features and rules, it may become an important driver of a successful urban development trajectory, as testified by many of the cities in our sample.

This paper contributes to the urban studies literature by grounding the analysis of the trade-off between culture and creativity at the urban scale into a new, solid empirical terrain but, like any other research, has limitations that offer opportunities for further investigation. In particular, caution should be exercised when interpreting our results: in addition to the reasons discussed above, the weak correlation between ‘Cultural Vibrancy’ and ‘Creative Economy’ might indeed be explained by the necessarily limited scope of the underlying indicators. Indicators on cultural events – a domain not easily amenable to precise measurement – are for instance out of the scope of the current version of the Monitor. Moreover, the current version of the Monitor does not include indicators related to critical social factors (such as artists’ displacement or precarity of culture-related jobs, etc.), and does not allow causal inferences, but only correlational analyses.

Future research should prioritise the development of a wider, richer European evidence base that looks at those dimensions that currently escape from comprehensive, comparable measurement such as, for instance, the social sustainability dimension of cultural activity. This would be crucial to improve our understanding of what makes different culture-led urban policy approaches more or less successful. A deeper understanding becomes particularly urgent in the context of the post-pandemic recovery scenario, where cultural and creative sectors worldwide have been hit especially hard. We also need to understand better the success vs. failure factors at work in small and medium sized cities, but also semi-urban and rural areas that are considerably investing in culture. Conventional explanations in terms of agglomeration economies fail to capture the essence of the local mechanisms at play in such contexts, and their performance is consequently likely not to be fully explained by the most conventional indicators of cultural vibrancy and creative economy, which have been typically tailored to urban economies.

We therefore face a new, stimulating research and policy design agenda. Despite its by now long history, the creative city debate needs to be rejuvenated with fresh approaches, a stronger evidence base, and new policy principles.

References

- Alsayela, A., de Jong, M. & Fransen, J. (2022). Can creative cities be inclusive too? How do Dubai, Amsterdam and Toronto navigate the tensions between creativity and inclusiveness in their adoption of city brands and policy initiatives?, *Cities*, 128(5).
- Barnes, T., & Hutton, T. (2009). Situating the new economy: Contingencies of regeneration and dislocation in Vancouver's inner city. *Urban Studies*, 46(5-6), 1247–1269.
- Bianchini, F. & Landry, C. (1994) *The Creative City: A Methodology for assessing Urban Vitality and Viability*, Stroud, Glos.: Comedia.
- Bianchini, F. & Parkinson, M. (Eds) (1993) *Cultural Policy and Urban Regeneration: The Western European Experience*. Manchester: Manchester University Press.
- Boix, R., Hervás-Oliver, J. L., & De Miguel-Molina, B. (2015). Micro-geographies of creative industries clusters in Europe: From hot spots to assemblages. *Papers in Regional Science*, 94(4), 753–772. <https://doi.org/10.1111/pirs.12094>

Chatterton, P. (2000). Will the real Creative City please stand up? *City*, 4(3), 390–397. <https://doi.org/10.1080/713657028>

Cooke, P., & Lazzeretti, L. (2007). Creative cities, cultural clusters and Local economic development. In *Creative Cities, Cultural Clusters and Local Economic Development*. <https://doi.org/10.4337/9781847209948>

Cunningham, S. (2012). The creative cities discourse: Production and/or consumption? In *Cities, Cultural Policy and Governance* (pp. 111–121). <https://doi.org/10.4135/9781446254523.n8>

Curtin, M. (2003). Media Capital: Towards the Study of Spatial Flows. *International Journal of Cultural Studies*, 6(2), 202–228. <https://doi.org/10.1177/13678779030062004>

Darlow, A. (1996). Cultural Policy and Urban Sustainability: Making a missing link?, *Planning Practice & Research*, 11(3), 291-302.

Daubaraite, U., & Startiene, G. (2012). Creative Industries Mapping In Kaunas County. *Economics and Management*, 17(3), 1178–1184. <https://doi.org/10.5755/J01.EM.17.3.2140>

Evans, G. & Shaw, P. (2004) *The Contribution of Culture to Regeneration in the UK: A report to the DCMS*, London: London Metropolitan University.

Florida, R. (2017). *The new urban crisis: how our cities are increasing inequality, deepening segregation, and failing the middle class - and what we can do about it* (Basic Books, ed.).

Florida, R. (2002). *The rise of the creative class: and how it's transforming work, leisure, community and everyday life*. Basic Books.

Florida, R. (2005). *The flight of the creative class : the new global competition for talent*. HarperBusiness.

Grodach, C. (2012) Before and after the Creative City: The Politics of Urban Cultural Policy in Austin, Texas, *Journal of Urban Affairs*, 34:1, 81-97, DOI: 10.1111/j.1467-9906.2011.00574.x

Hall, P. (2004). Creativity, culture, knowledge and the city. *Built Environment*, 30(3), 256–258. <https://doi.org/10.2148/benv.30.3.256.54306>

Hall, P. (2000) Creative cities and economic development, *Urban Studies*, 37(4), pp. 639–649.

Jacobs, J. (1961). *The Death and Life of Great American Cities*. Retrieved from <https://www.socialcapitalgateway.org/it/content/book/jacobs-j-1961-death-and-life-great->

american-cities-new-york-random-house

Kagan, S.J. & Hahn, J. (2012). Creative Cities and (Un) Sustainability: From Creative Class to Sustainable Creative Cities, *Culture and Local Governance*, 3(1-2), 11-27, DOI: 10.18192/clg-cgl.v3i1.182.

Landry, C. (2000). *The Creative City: A Toolkit for Urban Innovators*. Retrieved from <https://www.routledge.com/The-Creative-City-A-Toolkit-for-Urban-Innovators/Landry/p/book/9781844075980>

Landry, C., & Bianchini, F. (1995). The creative city. In *Demos*.

Lash, S., & Urry, J. (1994). Economies of signs and space. In *Economies of signs and space*. <https://doi.org/10.2307/2076072>

Lazzeretti, L., Boix, R., & Capone, F. (2008). Do Creative Industries Cluster? Mapping Creative Local Production Systems in Italy and Spain. *Industry & Innovation*, 15(5), 549–567. <https://doi.org/10.1080/13662710802374161>

Leslie, D. & Catungal, J. P. (2012) Social Justice and the Creative City: Class, Gender and Racial Inequalities, *Geography Compass*, 6 (3): 111-122.

Leslie, D., & Rantisi, N. (2006). Governing the design economy in Montreal, Canada. *Urban Affairs Review*, 41(3), 309–337.

Lorentzen, A., & Van Heur, B. (2011). *Cultural Political Economy of Small Cities*. <https://doi.org/10.4324/9780203803844>

Lorenzen, M., & Frederiksen, L. (2008). Why do Cultural Industries Cluster? Localization, Urbanization, Products and Projects. In P. Cook & L. R. (Eds.), *Creative Cities, Cultural Clusters, and Local Economic Development* (Cheltenham, pp. 155–179). Retrieved from https://econpapers.repec.org/bookchap/elgeechap/12738_5f7.htm

Mareque, M., Creo, E. de P., & Álvarez-Díaz, M. (2021). Exploring creative tourism based on the cultural and creative cities (C3) index and using bootstrap confidence intervals. *Sustainability (Switzerland)*, 13(9). <https://doi.org/10.3390/SU13095145>

Markusen, A. (2006). Urban Development and the Politics of a Creative Class: Evidence from a Study of Artists. *Environment and Planning A*, 38(10), 1921–1940. <https://doi.org/10.1068/a38179>

McCann, E. J. (2007). Inequality and politics in the creative city-region: Questions of livability and state strategy. *International Journal of Urban and Regional Research*, 31(1),

188–196.

McCarthy, J. (2002) 'Entertainment-led Regeneration: The Case of Detroit', *Cities*, 19 (2): 105-111.

McLean, H. (2014). Digging into the creative city: A feminist critique. *Antipode*, 46(3), 669–690. <https://doi.org/10.1111/anti.12078>

Miles, M. (2000) *The Uses of Decoration: Essays in the Architectural Everyday*, Chichester: Wiley.

Miles, M. (1997) *Art, Space and the City*, London: Routledge.

Miles, S., & Paddison, R. (2005). Introduction: The rise and rise of culture-led urban regeneration. *Urban Studies*, 42(5–6), 833–839. <https://doi.org/10.1080/00420980500107508>

Montgomery, J. (1990) Cities and the art of cultural planning, *Planning Practice and Research*, 5(3), pp. 17–24.

Montalto, V., Tacao Moura, C. J., Langedijk, S., & Saisana, M. (2019). Culture counts: An empirical approach to measure the cultural and creative vitality of European cities. *Cities*, 89. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.cities.2019.01.014>

Montalto, Valentina., Tacao Moura, C. J., Alberti, V., Saisana, M., Panella, F., & European Commission. Joint Research Centre. (2019). *The Cultural and Creative Cities Monitor : 2019 edition*. <https://doi.org/10.2760/257371>

Montalto, V, Tacao Moura, C. J., Langedijk, S., & Saisana, M. (2017). *The Cultural and Creative Cities Monitor. 2017 Edition*. Retrieved from <http://publications.jrc.ec.europa.eu/repository/bitstream/JRC107331/kj0217787enn.pdf>

Navarro Yáñez, C. J. (2013). Do 'creative cities' have a dark side? Cultural scenes and socioeconomic status in Barcelona and Madrid (1991–2001). *Cities*, 35, 213–220. <https://doi.org/10.1016/J.CITIES.2013.05.007>

Novy, J., & Colomb, C. (2013). Struggling for the Right to the (Creative) City in Berlin and Hamburg: New Urban Social Movements, New 'Spaces of Hope'? *International Journal of Urban and Regional Research*, 37(5), 1816–1838. <https://doi.org/10.1111/J.1468-2427.2012.01115.X>

Peck, J. (2005). Struggling with the creative class. *International Journal of Urban and Regional Research*, 29(4), 740–770. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1468-2427.2005.00620.x>

- Ponzini, D., & Rossi, U. (2010). Becoming a creative city: The entrepreneurial mayor, network politics and the promise of an urban renaissance, *Urban Studies*, 47(5), 1037–1057.
- Potts, J. (2009). Introduction: Creative industries & Innovation policy. *Innovation: Management, Policy & Practice*, 11(2), 138–147. Retrieved from <https://www.proquest.com/openview/7b9fffa7242801110b609bfad4e83af9/1?pq-origsite=gscholar&cbl=28517>
- Pratt, A. C. (1997). The cultural industries production system: A case study of employment change in Britain, 1984-91. *Environment and Planning A*, 1953–1974. <https://doi.org/10.1068/a291953>
- Pratt, A. C. (2011). The cultural contradictions of the creative city. *City, Culture and Society*, 2, 123–130. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ccs.2011.08.002>
- Richards, G., & Duif, L. (2018). *Small cities with big dreams : creative placemaking and branding strategies*.
- Sacco, P. L., Ferilli, G., & Tavano-Blessi, G. (2014). Understanding culture-led local development: A critique of alternative theoretical explanations. *Urban Studies*, 51(13), 2806–2821. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0042098013512876>
- Sacco, P. L., Crociata, A. (2013). A conceptual regulatory framework for the design and evaluation of complex, participative cultural planning strategies, *International Journal of Urban and Regional Research*, 37 (5), 1688-1706.
- Sacco, P. L., Williams, B., & Del Bianco, E. (2007). *The Power of the Arts in Vancouver: Creating a Great City*.
- Sassen, S. (1994). *Cities in a world economy*. Pine Forge Press.
- Saxenian, A. (1996). *Regional advantage : culture and competition in Silicon Valley and Route 128*. Harvard University Press.
- Scott, A. J. (2014). Beyond the Creative City: Cognitive–Cultural Capitalism and the New Urbanism, *Regional Studies*, 48:4, 565-578, DOI: 10.1080/00343404.2014.891010.
- Scott, A.J. (2010). Cultural economy and the creative field of the city, *Geografiska Annaler: Series B, Human Geography*, 92(2), 115-130.
- Scott, A. J. (2008). *Social Economy of the Metropolis: Cognitive–Cultural Capitalism and the Global Resurgence of Cities*. Oxford University Press, Oxford.
- Scott, A. J. (2006) Creative Cities: Conceptual issues and policy questions, *Journal of Urban*

Affairs, 28(1), 1-17.

Scott, A. J. (2000). The Cultural Economy of Cities: Essays on the Geography of Image-Producing Industries. In *The Cultural Economy of Cities: Essays on the Geography of Image-Producing Industries*. <https://doi.org/10.4135/9781446217481>

Scott, A. J. (1996). The Craft, Fashion, and Cultural-Products Industries of Los Angeles: Competitive Dynamics and Policy Dilemmas in a Multisectoral Image-Producing Complex. *Http://Dx.Doi.Org/10.1111/j.1467-8306.1996.Tb01755.X*, 86(2), 306–323. <https://doi.org/10.1111/J.1467-8306.1996.TB01755.X>

Storper, M., & Scott, A. J. (2009). Rethinking human capital, creativity and urban growth. *Journal of Economic Geography*. <https://doi.org/10.1093/jeg/lbn052>

Tasmin, C. & O' Brien, D. (2012) The "scouse wedding" and other myths: Reflections on the evolution of a "Liverpool model" for culture-led urban regeneration, *Cultural Trends*, 21(2):93-101, DOI: 10.1080/09548963.2012.674749.

Throsby, D. (2001). *Economics and Culture*. Cambridge University Press, London.

Turok, I. (2003). Cities, Clusters and Creative Industries: The Case of Film and Television in Scotland. *European Planning Studies*, 11(5), 549–565. <https://doi.org/10.1080/09654310303652>

Yencken, D. (1988). The Creative City. *Meanjin Quarterly*. Retrieved from <https://meanjin.com.au/essays/the-creative-city/>

UNCHS (Habitat) (2004), *The State of the World's Cities 2004/5: Globalization and Urban Culture*, Nairobi: UNCHS; London: Earthscan.

Vickery, J. (2007) *The emergence of culture-led regeneration : a policy concept and its discontents. Working Paper*. Coventry: University of Warwick. Centre for Cultural Policy Studies. Research papers, Vol.9.

Zeng, M., Wang, F., Xiang, S., Lin, B., Gao, C., & Li, J. (2020). Inheritance or variation? Spatial regeneration and acculturation via implantation of cultural and creative industries in Beijing's traditional compounds. *Habitat International*, 95, 102071.